The mortgage pre-screening assistant

Foundations of Agentic Logic · fictional composite, not based on any named institution

The scenario

A retail bank has piloted a tool that reads incoming mortgage applications, checks them against lending criteria, and drafts a recommendation (“proceed to underwriter”, “request further documents”, or “likely decline”) for a human loan officer to review. It was introduced as “a drafting aid to save officers time.”

Six months in, three things have changed quietly:

- Officers report they now approve the tool's draft recommendation in the vast majority of cases without materially editing it.
- The tool was recently given access to a broader internal document store “to give it more context”, including some historical case notes that mention protected characteristics of past applicants.
- A new version of the tool was deployed that can now also draft the outbound message to the applicant, not just the internal recommendation.

Discussion questions

1. **Where did this system start on the autonomy spectrum, and where is it now? What changed: the system, or how people use it?**

2. **What's the blast radius if this tool is wrong, unsupervised, for a day? Has that blast radius grown with the three changes above, even though no one explicitly decided to make the system “more autonomous”?**

3. **The tool's document access grew informally (“to give it more context”). What would security trimming have needed to look like for that expansion to be safe?**

4. **If you were reviewing this system today for the first time, what's the first question you'd ask?**